ECON-241: Intermediate Microeconomics

Fall 2026 syllabus and fourteen-week course schedule

Course purpose

Intermediate Microeconomics follows how consumers and firms make choices when resources, information, and alternatives are limited. The course moves from competitive markets and consumer choice to elasticity, market power, competition, welfare, and pricing design. VidStack is the shared case: a streaming service with different customer segments, fixed content costs, uneven information, and a difficult pricing decision.

How to reason in this course

In ECON-241, a model is a tool for a decision rather than a graph to memorize. Start by naming the decision-maker and the constraint, choose the comparison the model requires, show the calculation or table, interpret the result in the market story, and state the limitation that would most change the recommendation. The VidStack materials are intentionally specific enough to support analysis and incomplete enough to require judgment. Do not turn an observed pattern into a causal claim without identifying the counterfactual and the evidence that would separate competing explanations.

Course schedule and material map

Week	Topic	Teaching record
Week 1	Markets, demand, and supply	Market equilibrium, shifts, and shortages. Build a baseline VidStack demand and supply schedule, then separate a change in buyer preferences from a change in content-delivery cost.
Week 2	Consumer choice and willingness to pay	Reservation value, marginal benefit, and consumer surplus. Use the six-customer schedule to calculate who gains from a flat price, who exits after an increase, and what the result does not establish about fairness.
Week 3	Costs, revenue, and profit	Fixed cost, marginal cost, and the firm's decision. Separate the content budget from the incremental cost of serving one more subscriber before comparing revenue and profit.
Week 4	Elasticity, incidence, and revenue	Percentage responsiveness and total revenue. Calculate midpoint elasticity before interpreting the VidStack price increase. A line's slope is not the same thing as elasticity.
Week 5	Market power, markup, and churn	Marginal revenue, monopoly pricing, and retention. Compare a short-run price result with customer lifetime value and identify the churn data that would change the recommendation.
Week 6	Price discrimination and tier design	Segmentation, fences, and cannibalization. Build a menu with a target use case, a price, a feature bundle, a fence, and a downgrade test for every tier.

Week	Topic	Teaching record
Week 7	Interactive Pricing Session	Evidence-grounded pricing recommendations. Frame the subscriber loss, build a tier table, revise it after a cannibalization challenge, and state the next evidence to collect.
Week 8	Oligopoly and strategic pricing	Best responses and competitive reaction. Use a payoff table to reason about an entrant rather than treating a competitor's listed price as the whole strategic environment.
Week 9	Bundling and two-sided platforms	Bundles, advertising, and cross-side effects. Compare separate prices and a bundle while explaining how a viewer-side offer changes advertiser value.
Week 10	Information, signaling, and quality	Adverse selection and credible signals. Assess which quality claims a weaker platform could cheaply imitate and which trial or guarantee would actually be informative.
Week 11	Welfare, surplus, and policy	Consumer surplus, producer surplus, and policy. Evaluate a catalog merger without confusing a transfer between buyers and sellers with deadweight loss.
Week 12	Behavioral pricing and fairness	Reference prices, trust, and consumer response. Design an experiment that distinguishes a reference-price effect from a real change in product quality or customer trust.
Week 13	Final project workshop	Model choice, evidence, and revision. Test whether a peer's pricing recommendation has a visible mechanism, a defensible evidence table, and an honest limitation.
Week 14	Review and synthesis	Integrated microeconomic reasoning. Choose the model that answers the decision in front of you and name the observation that would make you switch models.

Week 1: Markets, demand, and supply

Market equilibrium, shifts, and shortages

Build a baseline VidStack demand and supply schedule, then separate a change in buyer preferences from a change in content-delivery cost.

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Use the lecture deck for definitions and diagram sequence, the reader for the longer explanation, and the evidence workbook for schedules, calculations, and interpretation prompts. A complete response identifies the relevant input, shows the comparison, explains the economic mechanism, and names what the current record cannot establish.

Week 2: Consumer choice and willingness to pay

Reservation value, marginal benefit, and consumer surplus

Use the six-customer schedule to calculate who gains from a flat price, who exits after an increase, and what the result does not establish about fairness.

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Week 3: Costs, revenue, and profit

Fixed cost, marginal cost, and the firm's decision

Separate the content budget from the incremental cost of serving one more subscriber before comparing revenue and profit.

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Week 4: Elasticity, incidence, and revenue

Percentage responsiveness and total revenue

Calculate midpoint elasticity before interpreting the VidStack price increase. A line's slope is not the same thing as elasticity.

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Week 5: Market power, markup, and churn

Marginal revenue, monopoly pricing, and retention

Compare a short-run price result with customer lifetime value and identify the churn data that would change the recommendation.

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Week 6: Price discrimination and tier design

Segmentation, fences, and cannibalization

Build a menu with a target use case, a price, a feature bundle, a fence, and a downgrade test for every tier.

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Week 7: Interactive Pricing Session

Evidence-grounded pricing recommendations

Frame the subscriber loss, build a tier table, revise it after a cannibalization challenge, and state the next evidence to collect.

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Week 8: Oligopoly and strategic pricing

Best responses and competitive reaction

Use a payoff table to reason about an entrant rather than treating a competitor's listed price as the whole strategic environment.

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Week 9: Bundling and two-sided platforms

Bundles, advertising, and cross-side effects

Compare separate prices and a bundle while explaining how a viewer-side offer changes advertiser value.

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Week 10: Information, signaling, and quality

Adverse selection and credible signals

Assess which quality claims a weaker platform could cheaply imitate and which trial or guarantee would actually be informative.

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Week 11: Welfare, surplus, and policy

Consumer surplus, producer surplus, and policy

Evaluate a catalog merger without confusing a transfer between buyers and sellers with deadweight loss.

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Week 12: Behavioral pricing and fairness

Reference prices, trust, and consumer response

Design an experiment that distinguishes a reference-price effect from a real change in product quality or customer trust.

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Week 13: Final project workshop

Model choice, evidence, and revision

Test whether a peer's pricing recommendation has a visible mechanism, a defensible evidence table, and an honest limitation.

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Week 14: Review and synthesis

Integrated microeconomic reasoning

Choose the model that answers the decision in front of you and name the observation that would make you switch models.

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